

Distributed Optical Fibre Sensing: Where Elegant Physics Gives Rise to Smart Systems

Luc Thévenaz

EPFL - Ecole Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne, Institute of Electrical and Micro Engineering, Station 11, 1015 Lausanne, Switzerland, luc.thevenaz@epfl.ch

Abstract *Distributed optical fibre sensing exploits Rayleigh, Brillouin and Raman scattering in silica fibres to measure physical quantities such as temperature and strain with spatial resolution. Each scattering mechanism offers distinct advantages and trade-offs. The operating principles, performance limits, and future prospects, notably hollow-core fibres, are reviewed. ©2026 The Author*

General overview

Distributed optical fibre sensing is a fascinating field requiring broad expertise spanning several disciplines. Since a sensor is dedicated to measuring an external quantity, an extensive knowledge of the optical response of a material to that quantity is essential. The optical processes by which information about the measured quantity is encoded into an optical signature must then be thoroughly understood.

In the case of purely distributed fibre sensors, these processes are the natural scatterings observed in silica, namely Rayleigh, Brillouin and Raman scattering, which constitute the elegant physics underpinning this field.

The next step is to devise an experimental configuration enabling the spatially-resolved measurement of the quantity of interest. The most straightforward configuration is the time-domain reflectometer, in which the continuous backscattering of a short pulse is detected as a function of time.

The spatial resolution is directly related to the pulse duration: at any given moment, the pulse covers a finite segment of the fibre, eventually addressing its full length during propagation.

A sharp spatial resolution requires a short pulse, which carries less energy and therefore produces a weaker backscattered signal. In addition, the detection bandwidth must be large enough to resolve the spatial granularity, resulting in a double penalty: since the performance of such sensors is ultimately governed by the signal-to-noise ratio, improving spatial resolution degrades it on two fronts simultaneously.

This gives rise to a fundamental trade-off common to all distributed fibre sensors: spatial resolution (which fixes the pulse energy), distance range (limited by fibre loss), and measurement time (proportional to the averaging process) are interrelated parameters: improving one necessarily compromises one or both of the others.

Since a very fine resolution is generally not required over very long distances where

attenuation becomes critical, alternative configurations such as frequency-domain or correlation-domain techniques can be implemented, which are more stringent on the number of resolved points (distance range over spatial resolution).

Each of the natural scatterings exploited delivers information through a distinct physical process, illustrating the rich diversity of this field of photonics, as described in the sections below.

Raman-based sensing

Historically, this is the first distributed sensor capable of measuring an environmental quantity, namely the temperature, proposed by Dakin *et al* in 1985 [1].

It is also the only distributed sensing technique based on a purely quantum process, governing the thermal generation of optical phonons.

Thermally-activated molecular vibrations give rise to scattered photons experiencing a frequency shift proportional to the molecular vibration frequencies, typically around 13 THz (or approximately 100 nm at a wavelength of 1550 nm).

The statistics of optical phonons are governed by the Bose-Einstein distribution, making their population strongly temperature-dependent. For a given vibration mode, the average number of phonons at ambient temperature is approximately 0.14, well below unity.

Each molecular vibration gives rise to two spontaneously scattered photons:

- one undergoing a frequency upshift, annihilating a phonon (Anti-Stokes process), with a scattering amplitude proportional to the average number of thermally-activated phonons;
- one undergoing a frequency downshift, creating an additional phonon (Stokes process), with a scattering amplitude proportional to the average number of thermally-activated phonons plus one.

Since the average phonon population is significantly less than one, the Stokes wave is only weakly temperature-dependent, whereas the Anti-Stokes wave retains a strong thermal

dependence. The temperature can therefore be extracted by comparing the relative amplitudes of the two waves.

These two waves are easily separated spectrally owing to their large wavelength difference (~ 200 nm), making the measurement setup straightforward to implement and resulting in a relatively inexpensive instrument. This simplicity has ensured solid commercial success, and Raman distributed sensors remain the preferred solution in many installations where only temperature monitoring is required.

The principal limitation of Raman-based sensors lies in the very low scattering cross-section: the signals are extremely weak, requiring long averaging times and imposing strict constraints on acceptable propagation loss, which in turn limits the achievable distance range.

Brillouin-based sensing

The use of Brillouin scattering for distributed fibre sensing was originally proposed by Horiguchi et al. [2, 3] in 1990. It attracted immediate interest for two reasons: it can measure fibre deformation (strain) in addition to temperature, and it was soon demonstrated to cover distance ranges significantly greater than Raman-based sensors, extending to several tens of kilometres [4, 5].

Brillouin scattering can be understood as Bragg reflection from a travelling acoustic wave propagating along the fibre. The reflected wave experiences a Doppler shift proportional to the acoustic velocity in the medium.

By measuring this frequency shift, the acoustic velocity can be determined with high precision, a quantity that depends on both temperature and material density, the latter being affected by fibre deformation. The technique is intrinsically robust, since the information is encoded in frequency rather than intensity.

Strong responses can be obtained by exploiting the stimulated form of the scattering, which requires a strong pump pulse and a weak, counter-propagating continuous probe wave. A large energy transfer occurs between the two waves when their frequency difference matches the acoustic resonance frequency.

The main drawback of this approach is the need for access to both fibre ends, which may be impractical in some field applications. Furthermore, the frequency difference (~ 11 GHz) between pump and probe must be extremely stable and tuned with MHz-level accuracy, which is highly challenging when using independent laser sources.

A significant advance was made when it was demonstrated that all interacting signals could be synthesised from a single laser source using

microwave modulation [6, 7], ensuring ideal stability and accuracy. This was a pivotal step in enabling field deployment.

Exploiting stimulated Brillouin scattering, a nonlinear optical process, opened new avenues for sophisticated configurations, including coding schemes for high spatial resolution [8–12] and noise reduction techniques [13, 14]. Such sensors have been rigorously modelled, enabling full prediction of measurement accuracy from the signal-to-noise ratio and the measurement parameters [15].

A variant based on spontaneous Brillouin scattering was proposed at an early stage [16], circumventing the need for access to both fibre ends. This single-ended reflectometry configuration is widely favoured by end-users; however, it offers little room for performance-enhancing sophistication, and the chaotic nature of the response results in a 10 dB signal-to-noise ratio penalty [17].

Brillouin-based sensing remains today the preferred solution for long-range distributed measurement of temperature and/or strain.

Rayleigh-based sensing

Although Rayleigh scattering is ubiquitous in all disordered media, readily observable, and exhibits the largest cross-section of all scattering processes in silica, it is paradoxically the most difficult to model and was the last of the three mechanisms to be developed for sensing purposes. The technique discussed here is not the incoherent, classical OTDR used to measure loss distribution along a fibre, but its coherent counterpart, which carries information about phase changes of the light propagating along the fibre.

Rayleigh scattering arises from density fluctuations in the material, a direct consequence of the amorphous nature of solid silica, giving rise to the isotropic generation of scattered waves of random amplitude at very closely-spaced discrete locations along the fibre.

At any given time, the light backreflected from a coherent pulse is formed by the superposition of a vast number of tiny scattered waves of random amplitude and distinct phase, generated at the many discrete locations spanned by the pulse.

The net effect is to produce a backscattered wave with the same spectral distribution as the incident pulse, but in which every frequency component carries a random phase, in contrast to the well-ordered phase of a deterministic signal. In other words, Rayleigh scattering transforms a coherent signal into its chaotic version sharing the same spectral distribution.

This effect was properly described by Peter

Healey of British Telecom in the 1980s, a body of work that is widely overlooked today [18–20]. The resulting backscattered signal takes the form of a continuous wave with a random, noise-like, jagged intensity pattern following an exponential distribution. This pattern is stationary (it does not vary in time) and is reproducible provided experimental conditions remain strictly unchanged: a stable laser wavelength and no phase perturbation along the fibre.

Any small change in these conditions produces a modified waveform that appears entirely different. The system is therefore intrinsically highly sensitive to phase changes, and this property has been extensively exploited for distributed acoustic sensing (DAS) by detecting local, time-varying intensity changes.

DAS is today one of the most widely deployed distributed sensing modalities, owing to its extremely simple optical configuration and high sensitivity, with applications in intrusion detection [21, 22] and seismic monitoring [23, 24].

Rayleigh-based sensing is also used in a frequency-domain variant for distributed temperature and strain measurements [25, 26]. A time-domain version exists as well, but its extraordinarily high sensitivity to temperature and strain renders it impractical in most real-world situations [27–29].

Future trends

Distributed optical fibre sensing has matured into an established technology, with several commercial instruments now available. Ongoing progress is directed towards longer distance ranges, faster measurements, and improved accuracy, all of which ultimately depend on advances in signal-to-noise ratio.

Silica itself imposes strict fundamental limits: nonlinear effects cap the maximum power of the interrogating signals, while the intrinsic linear loss of silica sets a floor on the detectable power. In this context, novel hollow-core fibres, which substantially relax both of these constraints, hold considerable promise for improving sensor performance.

However, the favourable properties of hollow-core fibres stem largely from the suppression of scattering processes — which are precisely the mechanisms that generate the sensing signature. Rayleigh and Raman scattering appear largely unexploitable in hollow-core fibres; Brillouin scattering, on the other hand, can exhibit a remarkable response when the fibre is filled with a high-pressure gas, outperforming the response of silica [30] and enabling absolute thermometry down to cryogenic temperatures [31].

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